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Magic, Religion & Science

Definition of Magic

SIR JAMES GEORGE FRAZER

- **Magic is the technique designed to achieve specific goals by manipulating the supernatural**
- Magic is a **Technique** - i.e., it is an aspect of technology
- This technology involves certain **skills and competence for manipulating or controlling** the supernatural.
- **Specific Goals** may be ensuring good crops, replenishment of game, bringing in rains, creation of famine, illness and death in humans - magic is a means for good as well as bad
- Magic came into existence earlier than religion

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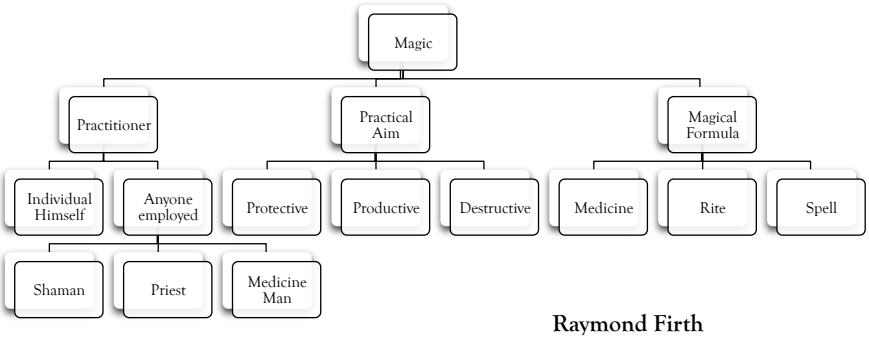
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Definition of Magic

BROWNISLAW MALINOWSKI

- **Magic consists of the superstitious acts and beliefs through which individuals try to control nature where their technology and natural techniques are insufficient**
- Recourse to magic is taken only during **unexpected conditions**
- Unexpected conditions result in **anxiety**
- Function of magic is to alleviate anxiety

Elements of Magic



Raymond Firth

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Forms of Magic

- **FRAZER'S CLASSIFICATION**
- **Sir James Frazer** classified magical practices into two forms on the **basis of laws or principles of thought** associated with those practices
- He found that magical formulae are based on **two principles of thought**
- **Law of Similarity - like produces like**
- **Law of contact - once in contact, always in contact**

Forms of Magic

LAW OF SIMILARITY

- The magic that is associated with law of similarity is called **Homeopathic Magic, Imitative Magic or Mimetic Magic**
- Homeopathic magic is the **most familiar** form of magic
- It is an attempt to injure an enemy or destroy an enemy by injuring or destroying an image of him
- This is in a belief that *just as the image suffers, so does the man and that when it perishes he must die*
- **Ex. Oraons of Chotanagpur** / Burning of effigies

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Forms of Magic

- **LAW OF CONTACT**
- The type of magic based on this principle is called **Contagious Magic**
- This form of magic is based on the principle *Once in contact is always in contact*
- It is a **magical sympathy** which is supposed to exist between a man and any severed portion of his person, as his hair or nails, so that whoever gets possession of human hair or nails may work his will, at any distance, upon the person from whom they were cut.
- Found in many tribal societies

Forms of Magic

- Many do not use each other's clothing, not for any reason of hygiene, but because clothes are regarded as part of that person's body who wore them first
- The main implication is that **once a part, always a part**
- It is for this reason that the personal effects of the dead are not made use of by many primitive groups but are instead buried or cremated along with the dead body.

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Forms of Magic

RAYMOND FIRTH'S CLASSIFICATION

- Classified into **Three types**
  - **Productive Magic**
  - **Protective Magic**
  - **Destructive Magic**

Forms of Magic

Productive Magic

- Includes magic for Productive purposes
- Ex. Magic for rain making, magic for harvesting, successful fishing, love making
- It is **socially approved magic**
- It serves as a **stimulus** in any economic and social activity.

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Forms of Magic

Protective Magic

- Includes taboos to guard property, to avert misfortunes, accidents while traveling, cure for sickness etc.
- Ex. Wearing of amulets and talismans
- **Socially approved magic**
- It is a form of **Social Control**

Forms of Magic

Destructive Magic

- Magic to destroy someone's property, life, harvest etc.
- It can be **socially disapproved or approved**
- Destructive magic is in the form of **Sorcery and witchcraft**

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Forms of Magic

- Some classify magic into **Black Magic and White Magic**
- For these people, Black magic is **Malevolent Magic** and White magic is **Benevolent Magic**
- This implies that White magic is Protective and Productive magic and Black magic is Destructive magic
- Still some classify Sorcery and Witchcraft as Black magic
- However, Frazer considers Sorcery as also Malevolent magic, i.e., it can also be protective and productive

Magic, Witchcraft & Sorcery

- **Harmful Sorcery** is the use of magic to **deliberately attempt to harm or destroy another person, group or community**
- The individual who practices sorcery is called a **Sorcerer**
- If **deliberate activity** is undertaken by an individual to harm someone, it is sorcery
- **Unconscious action** of individual for the purpose of doing harm is witchcraft
- Just as sorcery requires sorcerer, witchcraft requires witches

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Magic, Witchcraft & Sorcery

- But witches are **not individuals who have employed magic to destroy** people, crops or property, as the sorcerers
- Witches are individuals who have **evil intentions or activities attributed to them**
- **Witchcraft is actually ascribed to them**
- Thus the **practice of sorcery actually occurs, but the practice of witchcraft is imagined to have occurred**

Magic, Witchcraft & Sorcery

- Sorcery is sometimes socially approved and sometimes socially disapproved (Frazer)
- Often sorcery is a from of social control
- Witchcraft is socially disapproved and is always bad morally

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Sorcerers & Witches

- In contrast to the shamans, who have fairly high status in the society, sorcerers and witches of both sexes tend to have very low social and economic status in their society.
- Sorcerers and witches are usually feared because they are thought to know how to invoke the supernatural to cause illness, injury and death.
- Sorcerers use materials and evidence of sorcery is easy to identify and locate
- Witchcraft is accomplished purely by thought and emotion – but difficulty in finding evidence has not stopped people from killing witches – Telangana region of AP

Similarities between Magic & Science

1. Both assume that certain **causes create certain effects**
2. Both are governed by a **body of principles** and reveal how the practitioners have to proceed
3. Both are oriented towards a **desired goals**
4. Both reveal the confidence of humans in their ability to bring about certain **desired results**

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SIMILARITIES BETWEEN MAGIC AND RELIGION

1. Both deal with **non empirical aspects** and beyond logic and experimentation
2. Both are symbolic and consider ordinary **objects as endowed with magical power**
3. Both contain **ritual systems** that include spell, rites and procedures
4. Both contain **anthropopsychic entities** which are moody and are to be threatened or addressed
5. Both arise and function under **emotional stress**
6. Both are surrounded by **taboos and observances**

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN RELIGION AND SCIENCE

Religion	Science
Closed system of thought	Open system of thought
Its beliefs are sacred and considered to be absolute and not to be changed	Its principles are considered to be valid and are subjected to changes
There is little awareness of alternative theory and explanation	There is an awareness of alternative theory and explanation
It is of terminal value	It is more instrumental in value
It is always benevolent	It is both malevolent and benevolent
It is highly emotional	Detachment

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DIFFERENCE BETWEEN RELIGION AND MAGIC

Magic	Religion
Magic is Simple in its form (consists of Practitioner, Practical aim and formula)	It is complex in its form (consists of prayers, psychological experiences, preaching, recitation of myths, sacred literature, taboos, feasts, sacrifices, congregation, god etc)
Magic is everywhere uniform in its principles	Religious diversities are more common everywhere
Magic involves secrecy and is hence mostly individual	Religion is public and has a congregational aspect
Magic is most commonly used for good and bad purposes and is essentially anti ethical	Religion is most commonly used for good purposes and it is essentially moral

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN RELIGION AND MAGIC

Magic	Religion
Magic has concrete specificity of goal and hence is always directed toward a specific end	Religion has goals that are concerned with general welfare
Magic is manipulative and it involves coercion with the supernatural.	Religion is Supplicative. It involves human submission to the supernatural.
Magic includes only specialists but not followers and thus has professional - client relationships	Religion includes priests and many followers and it includes prophet - follower relations
Magicians are feared for they are generally malevolent	Religious specialists command respect for they are benevolent
A lesser degree of emotion is involved in magic	Religion involves a greater degree of emotion

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Religious Practitioners

Shamans, Priests, Sorcerers, Witches...

Significance

- They occupy high social status in any society
- They are important professionals as they are the only channel of communication between profane world and the sacred world
- They use different techniques like divination, spell, rituals, medicines to change events according to their wish
- In some societies, they also double up as political heads

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Shamans

- The word "Shaman" is from Tungus of Siberia
- He is a religious practitioner who devotes a part of his time to serve as an intermediary between God and Man
- He works alone since he applies his ability personally as an individual rather than as a representative of a group
- He is also called **Medicine Man** or **Witch Doctor**
- He learns to be a Shaman from an elderly Shaman



Shaman

- He may also gain his abilities by direct contact with supernatural beings
- He usually has a *Guardian Spirit* who visits him while he is in a state of trance
- Both male and female Shamans exist
- Shamans diagnose and cure diseases, weather control and locating game



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Priest

- He is a ceremonialist who doesn't operate individually but as a representative of the group and under its approval
- He is full-time practitioner and devotes all his time serving as an intermediary between group and God
- He is a member of a religious organization which provides him with special training



Priest

- Found in larger societies with fairly elaborate cultures and organized religious cults having elaborate theological doctrines and standardized ceremonies
- Prayers, offerings and sacrifices are his techniques



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Shaman VS Priest

Shaman	Priest
Part time	Full time
Works as an individual	Works as a representative of a group
Also a medicine man	Only a ceremonialist
Inherits or learns from other Shamans	Trained by religious organization
Helped by a guardian spirit	Helped by theology
Also a political head	Only has political influence
Cannot be removed	Can be removed
Makes the rules	Follows the rules

Mediums

- Mediums tend to be females who are part time practitioners who are asked by people to heal and communicate with divine when they are in possession or trance – a state where they are thought to be possessed by spirits.
- Mediums are described as having tremors, convulsions, seizures and temporary amnesia.



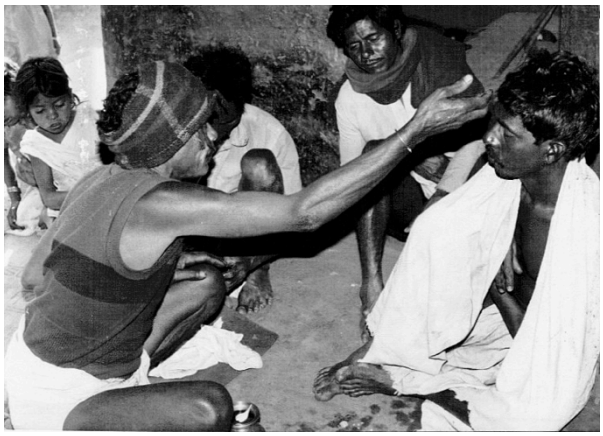
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Shaman



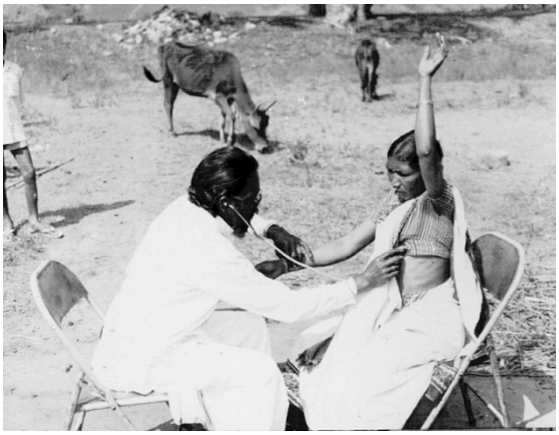
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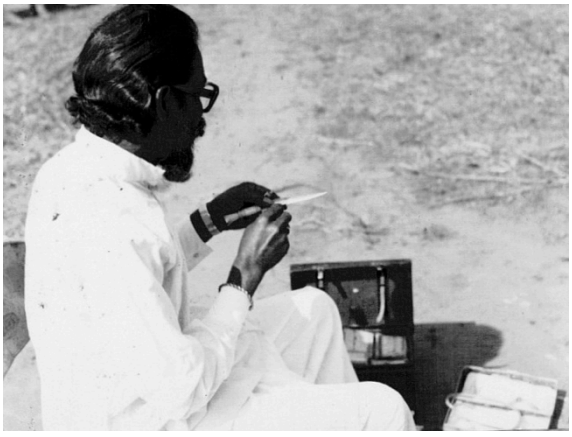
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Traditional Healer



Traditional Healer



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